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Star turn: Ashwin's skill with the new ball sets him apart as a spinner with versatility beyond typical spin attributes. VIJAY SONEJI

taken 520 wickets at a combined bowling average of 21.54. In the 43 home Tests, their numbers improve marginally: 448 wickets at 21.18. In comparison, Kumble and Harbhajan have a combined tally of 501 wickets from 54 Tests at a collective bowling average of 30.48. In the 34 home Tests, their numbers are thus: 356 wickets at a combined average of 27.47.

What further enamours Ashwin's feat of 500 Test wickets is that India's dominance over the last half-decade has been built around its incisive pace battery, spearheaded by all-condition quicks

Mohammed Shami and Jasprit Bumrah. This also meant that Ashwin has had to warm the bench on a few occasions, with India tending to pick a seam-bowling all-rounder, like Shardul Thakur, for No. 8, while going in with just one spinner, often Jadeja, in places such as South Africa, England, and Australia. Kumble and Harbhajan played 20 Tests outside India, while Ashwin and Jadeja played just eight together.

Ashwin serves as both the attacking focal point and the creative hub of this team.

Despite his integral role, ongoing discussions have always revolved around his effectiveness at the age of 37.

The highly skilled off-spinner is often evaluated within the limited scope of his ability to influence

matches in unfamiliar conditions. His exclusion from the playing XI in last year's World Test Championship final against Australia exemplifies the team's 'horses for courses' approach, despite Ashwin being India's leading wicket-taker in the WTC cycle.

This decision resulted in Ashwin missing six Test matches, including a pivotal five-Test series in England. His last appearance in England was in the 2021 WTC final in Southampton, where he had commendable figures of 25-10-45-4.

Ashwin's skill with the new ball sets him apart as a spinner with versatility, beyond typical spin attributes.

With the new ball, he bowls a swerving delivery with an upright seam and, through intelligent use of the crease, adeptly challenges both